ART ▼

FELINE **FRAMES**

A NEW EXHIBITION AT BENGALURU'S MUSEUM OF ART & PHOTOGRAPHY TRACES THE CAT'S ELUSIVE CHARM THROUGH CENTURIES OF INDIAN ART AND CRAFT

For centuries, the cat has occupied a unique place in the human imagination. Revered, mistrusted, adored and immortalised in art and literature, this enigmatic creature has long inspired artists and storytellers. The Museum of Art & Photography (MAP) in Bengaluru traces this fascination in its newest exhibition, *The Many Lives of the Cat*, on view until March 29, 2026.

The exhibition opens with a verse by Asadullah Khan Ghalib, translated by the late B.N. Goswamy, capturing the cat's graceful, otherworldly air. This establishes an experience traversing miniature paintings, sculptures, matchbox labels, sketchbooks and contemporary works. The exhibition draws from Goswamy's book *The Indian Cat*, which traces the animal's presence in proverbs, poetry and art. Curator Khushi Bansal notes the book's influence on MAP's own collection. "Professor Goswamy shows how cats have quietly slipped into countless stories and sayings across India, and that perspective encouraged us to look at our collection with fresh eyes," she says. "We realised we had a surprising number of works featuring cats, and that this could be the starting point for a larger narrative."



THE CAT EMBODIES MANY IDENTITIES: **PLAYFUL, POLITICAL, LOVING, MISCHIEVOUS.** THE EXHIBIT HIGHLIGHTS THOSE SHIFTING MEANINGS



What emerged was a story not just about cats in art, but about their ability to shift meaning. The exhibition places historical and contemporary works side by side. Featuring works by artists such as Jamini Roy, K.G. Subramanyan, Chandana Hore and Bhupendra Baghel, the show traces the cat's many incarnations across materials and moments in Indian art.

Through the displayed works, the cat embodies multiple identities: playful, political, loving, mischievous. True to MAP's focus on accessibility, the exhibition includes interactive and multi-sensory elements, including AR games, tactile works and audio stories. "The aim is to create a space where everyone feels welcome and where they can find something for themselves," Bansal shares.

Inviting warmth, curiosity and a touch of mischief, *The Many Lives of the Cat* makes visitors see this familiar creature anew. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

BOOKS ▶

A MULTI-FACETED MAVERICK

A centenary tribute, this collection frames *Ritwik Ghatak's tempestuous genius* into a vivid portrait beyond myth and melancholy



UNMECHANICAL
Ritwik Ghatak
Edited by Shamya Dasgupta
WESTLAND
₹899; 488 pages

As a non-Bengali lover of Ritwik Ghatak's cinema, I can safely say I'd been waiting for this book for decades. Many of us have glimpsed Ghatak through the mists of Ghatak mythology: genius, maverick, alcoholic, failure, traumatised forever by the partition of Bengal.... In his centenary year, this beautiful book reveals him through voices of family, students, collaborators, scholars—and Ghatak himself.

Including interviews and articles, these 50 'fragments' reveal Ghatak as he plays the